

Form follows function

In 1896, in his essay 'The Tall Office Building Artistically Considered', Louis Sullivan asserted that 'form ever follows function, and this is the law'. He saw this 'law' applying as much to architecture as it did to the form of a bird, or a tree, or the human body. From then on, 'Form follows function' became a guiding principle of modernism. Although Sullivan did not claim to have coined the phrase, his timing was apt, and he became recognized for its widespread adoption from the turn of the 20th century. He attributed the idea to the Vitruvian virtues of *firmitas, utilitas et venustas* (see here) – that a building should be sturdy, useful and beautiful.

Modernism now meant designing from the inside out, in an inversion of traditional architectural principles, so that the purpose of a building should dictate its form. And although Sullivan himself often used ornament – for instance, in his organic and interlacing friezes inspired by art nouveau – decorative elements were firmly subordinated to function.



Carson Pirie Scott Building in Chicago, Sullivan, 1903